

The Foreign Policy Impact of Trade-Based Status Gains: When China Overtakes the US as Top Export Destination

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Abstract

How do trade-based status gains affect UNGA voting convergence toward China? I argue that rank reversals in trade hierarchies create politically usable status cues: when China becomes a country's top export destination and remains there, policymakers can more easily justify selective diplomatic adjustment toward Beijing. I test the argument in Brazil, where China overtook the United States as the largest export destination in 2009, using Synthetic Difference-in-Differences on UNGA ideal-point distance. Brazil's ideal-point distance to China fell by 0.26 units, about 41 percent of its pre-treatment mean, and vote-level diagnostics show that the post-2009 movement is clearest in human-rights resolutions where China and the United States diverged. Brazilian newspaper evidence shows increased China-related trade salience after the rank reversal. Cross-country estimates from a goods-only interactive fixed-effects panel model show the same directional pattern among countries where China persistently becomes the top goods export destination. The evidence suggests that discrete and durable trade-status milestones can shape observable multilateral alignment beyond smooth trade growth.

1 Introduction

“China overtakes US as Brazil’s top trade partner”. That was a headline in many Brazilian newspapers in 2009 (A. Rodrigues 2009). The BBC ran a similar headline in 2021, when China surpassed the United States as the EU’s biggest trading partner (BBC News 2021). During a high-profile trip to Beijing with an unusually large business delegation, President Lula da Silva invoked the milestone by noting that China was Brazil’s largest export destination (Presidência da República Federativa do Brasil 2009).

Why do media outlets and political leaders dwell on discrete commercial milestones when the underlying flows are measured continuously? Export statistics are updated monthly, and journalists, diplomats, firms, and policymakers follow them long before one partner crosses a formal threshold. The puzzle, then, is not whether actors possess information about trade volumes. It is why a categorical change—China becomes number one—can matter politically despite adding little new information about the economic trend itself.

Answering this question rigorously is difficult because trade hierarchies are not randomly assigned. Existing work on economic statecraft and foreign-policy alignment usually treats economic exposure as continuous: as trade, lending, investment, aid, or coercive capacity accumulate, alignment is expected to shift through material leverage, changing interests, soft power, or domestic pressure (Flores-Macías and Kreps 2013; Urdinez et al. 2016; Kastner and Pearson 2021). A continuous-interdependence account would therefore expect foreign-policy alignment to move gradually with trade exposure, leverage, and economic dependence rather than at a discrete rank threshold. Domestic-political accounts, by contrast, would attribute foreign-policy change in cases such as Brazil to leadership ideology, autonomy, South-South cooperation, or broader foreign-policy reorientation (Neto 2011; Neto and Malamud 2015; P. Rodrigues, Urdinez, and De Oliveira 2019; Luis L. Schenoni et al. 2022). A further selection concern is that politically aligned countries may deepen economic ties with one another, making China’s rise in the trade hierarchy a consequence rather than a cause of prior diplomatic affinity (Gowa 1995; Davis and Pratt 2021; Strüver 2016). If alignment reflects only accumulated exposure, domestic-political reorientation, or prior

diplomatic affinity, however, no specific symbolic milestone such as becoming a top trade partner should matter.

I argue that such milestones matter because they mark trade-based status gains. The argument builds on research that treats status as socially recognized standing within international hierarchies, clubs, and local status orders (Paul, Larson, and Wohlforth 2014; Wolf 2011, 2019; Duque 2018; Renshon 2017; Götz 2021; MacDonald and Parent 2021; Røren 2024, 2025). By trade-based status, I mean the recognized standing of a foreign power within a country's hierarchy of economically consequential relationships. Trade volume is continuous, but status is categorical: a partner can move from being important to being understood as central. Once that reclassification becomes public, the relationship is no longer merely larger than before. It becomes easier for political actors to invoke as a national priority, to defend as strategically consequential, and to use as a justification for diplomatic adjustment.

Much of the China and rising-powers branch of this literature asks how rising states seek recognition, major-power status, or institutional standing, and how misrecognition can produce contestation or revisionism (Deng 2008; Larson and Shevchenko 2010; Ward 2017; Murray 2018; Mukherjee 2022). This argument relocates status from the ambitions of the rising power to the recognition practices of states. China's trade-based status gain occurs when another country publicly recategorizes China within its own hierarchy of external economic relationships – from an important partner to a central one. The mechanism is therefore status-theoretic, with Brazil as the audience and status-conferring actor.

Brazil is the strongest case for the theory. China displaced the United States, a politically salient incumbent and hegemonic benchmark; the rank reversal was publicly visible; and the Brazilian press allows the attention implication to be measured. The case is also substantively important because Lula-era Brazilian foreign policy is often described through autonomy, South-South activism, multipolarity, and Brazil's triangular position between the United States and China (Neto 2011; Neto and Malamud 2015; P. Rodrigues, Urdinez, and De Oliveira 2019; Luis L. Schenoni et al. 2022; Guilhon-Albuquerque 2014; Luis L. Schenoni and Leiva 2021; Brun and Covarrubias 2024; Coutinho and Rodriguez 2024).

To provide a causal credible estimate, I leverage the discreteness in China's status change to largest

Brazilian export destination to estimate its effect in the Brazilian foreign policy alignment using synthetic difference-in-differences (SDiD) on annual UNGA ideal-point distance to China. The estimate is an average post-2009 gap. Relative to Brazil's pre-treatment mean distance, the estimated reduction is 40.8 percent. UNGA voting is a standard measure to study alignment with China and other powers, linking votes to bilateral ties, ideology, sanctions, aid, Belt and Road membership, arms transfers, or Chinese economic returns (Potrafke 2009; Dreher and Jensen 2013; Strüver 2016; Yan and Zhou 2021; Garcia-Herrero, Storella, and Weil 2024; Steinert and Weyrauch 2024; He, Zheng, and Chen 2025; Lektzian and Biglaiser 2023).

To assess whether the pattern is specific to Brazil, I extend the analysis to a cross-country panel in which China enters and holds the top goods export-destination position to provide evidence that the rank-threshold pattern travels beyond the theory-generating case. The cross-country estimates are smaller in magnitude, consistent with a more heterogeneous sample, and point in the same direction as the Brazilian case. The panel evidence therefore strengthens the core claim that rank thresholds matter beyond the theory-generating case, while the Brazilian evidence shows the mechanism in detail.

The paper's contribution is to recast economic influence as a status process. Existing work usually treats trade exposure as a continuous source of leverage, interests, or domestic pressure. I show that accumulated trade growth can become politically consequential when it crosses a durable, publicly legible rank threshold: when China becomes and remains a country's leading export destination, the new status condition creates a persistent basis for selective diplomatic adjustment. In Brazil, China's rise to the top export-destination position made an already expanding commercial relationship politically usable as evidence of China's new centrality. That status gain helps explain why convergence appears selectively in UNGA voting. More broadly, the paper shows that status gains can emerge from economic hierarchies and shape observable diplomatic behavior.

The next section develops the status-threshold argument and derives observable implications. I then present the Brazil SDiD design and timing diagnostics, followed by issue-area and media evidence on the mechanism. The final empirical section evaluates whether durable China-top goods-export status is associated with similar movement in a broader cross-country panel.

2 Theory and hypotheses

A trade-based status shift differs from smooth growth in economic interdependence because it changes the category through which a foreign power is understood. Actors can observe trade shares, but political attention rarely follows continuous movements one percentage point at a time. It also organizes around coarse public labels: largest export market, number-one partner, top-ranked export destination. These labels simplify complex economic relationships and help journalists, politicians, organized interests, and diplomats coordinate attention (Bordalo, Gennaioli, and Shleifer 2022; Conlon 2025; Enke 2024; Graeber, Roth, and Sammon 2025). The number-one threshold matters because it can reclassify a rising power from one important commercial partner among several into the country's central economic partner. In this sense, export-destination rank operationalizes the trade-based status shift.

The cue should matter most when the new status also displaces a politically prominent incumbent. If a rising major power overtakes a minor partner, the event may remain a commercial fact with limited political resonance. If it overtakes the hegemonic incumbent, the same threshold takes on broader political meaning. It can be read as a visible loss of standing for the incumbent and as a public marker of the challenger's rise. Brazil falls squarely inside this high-salience condition: China became Brazil's largest export destination in 2009, displaced the United States, and contemporary coverage frequently described the event in broader top-partner language.

The mechanism has two steps. First, the status cue should increase attention. Media coverage should make the challenger and the bilateral trade relationship more visible after the threshold is crossed. Second, the cue should affect policy through justification. Once that power is publicly understood as a central economic partner, executives and diplomats can frame limited movement toward it as pragmatic recognition of the country's economic hierarchy rather than as ideological concession or opportunistic bandwagoning. This step can be gradual because UNGA positions are embedded in prior votes, bureaucratic routines, coalition commitments, and reputational constraints. The Brazilian SDiD design estimates the combined reduced-form effect of this status cue on UNGA distance to China.

The justification mechanism also implies a durability condition. The rank reversal is not expected to reshape foreign policy through a single decision at the moment China becomes number one.

Rather, it creates a public category that officials can invoke repeatedly across a sequence of selective adjustments. When China remains the leading export destination, presidents, ministers, diplomats, and organized interests can treat its centrality as a stable fact of the national economic hierarchy and use it to justify incremental diplomatic movement. A one-year China-top episode may attract attention, but it is a weaker treatment regime: it does not provide a durable basis for repeated public justification, bureaucratic recalibration, or cumulative foreign-policy adaptation.

2.1 From Attention to Selective Diplomatic Alignment

Trade-based status changes the terms on which selective accommodation can be justified. Some foreign-policy arenas are especially suitable for this kind of adjustment: they are visible to foreign governments and diplomatic audiences, materially less costly than treaties, military commitments, sanctions, or trade policy, and still capable of generating reputational exposure. In such arenas, governments can signal movement toward a newly central partner while preserving flexibility.

When a foreign power becomes publicly recognized as the country's leading trade partner, policymakers can frame limited convergence with that power as pragmatic recognition of economic importance rather than as ideological concession or opportunistic bandwagoning. The status gain can therefore lower the reputational cost of selected movement while increasing its diplomatic value.

The domestic pathway works through justification. Media coverage need not cause individual foreign-policy positions, and business groups need not lobby over specific diplomatic decisions. Public recognition of the partner's new standing changes what diplomats and executives can plausibly defend. Adjustment toward that partner becomes easier to present as alignment with national economic interests, especially in diplomatic settings where positions are visible internationally but relatively low-cost domestically.

This logic implies selective convergence. The mechanism should be most informative in issue areas where the country and the newly elevated partner previously differed and where movement is not costless. In domains tied to prior reputational commitments, adjustment toward the newly central partner requires a stronger rationale than in areas where the two countries already agree. Trade-based status supplies such a rationale by making the partner's economic centrality publicly available as a justification for diplomatic accommodation.

The main theoretical expectation is therefore that when a rising major power becomes a country's leading trade partner, the country's foreign policy should move closer to that power relative to its counterfactual path. The effect should be easiest to observe when the status gain displaces a politically prominent incumbent, especially a hegemonic benchmark such as the United States. The theory also implies an attention pattern: media coverage of the rising power and of the bilateral economic relationship should increase around the status shift.

3 Data and design

Empirically, the treatment is China becoming a country's largest export destination. I use "top trade partner" only as shorthand for the publicly salient Brazilian event when discussing contemporary framing. The Brazil SDiD and cross-country panel define treatment using largest-export-destination status.

The primary outcome is absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China, based on the annual ideal-point estimates of Bailey, Strezhnev, and Voeten (2017). Lower values indicate convergence toward China. This measure is preferable to raw annual agreement shares for the main design because it is less sensitive to changes in the UNGA agenda over time. I use resolution-level agreement diagnostics only to interpret where convergence appears strongest.

For Brazil, the treatment indicator equals one from 2009 onward, the first year China became Brazil's largest export destination. SDiD estimates Brazil's average post-2009 gap relative to a weighted synthetic counterfactual, using pre-treatment information to construct unit and time weights (Arkhangelsky et al. 2021). The design is reduced-form. Its credibility rests on pre-treatment fit, rank-versus-volume timing tests, donor-pool sensitivity, and outcome robustness.

The SDiD panel combines UNGA ideal points with covariates for trade exposure, macroeconomic conditions, power, geographic distance, political institutions, and trade-agreement ties. The complete panel covers 96 countries and 19 Brazil years for the main SDiD window (1997-2015). Trade data come from the International Trade and Production Database for Estimation (Borchert et al. 2021). The ITPD-E trade variable is measured in millions of current US dollars, and export-destination ranks are computed from exporter-importer flows.

The Brazil variables enter the design in three groups. The outcome is Brazil’s annual absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; the treatment is an indicator for years after China becomes Brazil’s largest export destination. The covariates measure trade exposure to China and the United States, relative power, geographic distance to Washington, leader ideology, macroeconomic stress, regime institutions, and U.S. trade-agreement ties. The cross-country panel uses the same outcome, but constructs treatment separately from goods-only export-destination ranks and a status-current risk set. Table 1 summarizes the country-year panel used to estimate Brazil’s synthetic counterfactual. The large number of observations reflects the donor pool and pre/post-treatment country-year structure of the SDiD design.

Table 1: Descriptive statistics for the country-year panel used in the Brazil SDiD design.

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Treatment	1824	0.00	0.06	0.00	1.00
UNGA distance to China	1824	0.92	0.80	0.00	4.22
UNGA distance to US	1824	2.64	0.92	0.00	5.06
Geographic distance to US	1824	0.00	0.50	-1.16	1.10
Trade share with China	1824	-0.01	0.49	-0.36	5.08
Trade share with US	1824	0.00	0.50	-0.41	1.87
Power index	1824	0.00	0.50	-0.12	5.01
Power gap to US	1824	0.03	0.49	-3.90	0.43
GDP per capita	1824	-0.00	0.50	-0.37	2.86
Exchange rate	1824	-0.00	0.49	-0.15	6.82
HoG left ideology	1824	0.39	0.49	0.00	1.00
Current account	1824	0.00	0.50	-3.32	2.64
Government deficit	1824	0.01	0.50	-6.68	3.39
Parliamentary system	1824	0.39	0.49	0.00	1.00
Military executive	1824	0.11	0.31	0.00	1.00
US trade agreement	1824	0.08	0.27	0.00	1.00

Note:

Country-year variables from the SDiD analytic panel; continuous covariates are rescaled in the estimation data, UNGA distances are ideal-point distances, and treatment is binary. Window: 1997-2015 SDiD analytic panel. Observations include Brazil and donor countries used to construct the synthetic counterfactual. The treatment mean is small because only Brazil is treated after 2009.

For the cross-country evidence beyond Brazil, the main sample is restricted to durable China-top export-destination periods measured with goods exports only. The treatment equals one only in country-years where China is the largest goods export destination and that China-top period lasts at least five observed years. Treated countries must first enter this status in or after 2000, after an observed prior year in which China was not number one. Countries that never reach China-top goods-export status remain controls. For treated countries, the main risk set keeps clean pre-entry non-China-top years and qualifying treated years, while excluding post-exit off-status years and short China-top episodes. This operationalization matches the salience logic more closely than either a one-year entry definition or an absorbing treatment rule: the theory expects political visibility, bureaucratic learning, and diplomatic adaptation to be clearer when the new trade hierarchy persists and is currently true. I compute partner ranks from ITPD-E goods sectors only, excluding services before ranks are constructed. For this panel, I use the `fect` counterfactual estimator with interactive fixed effects, which allows countries to load differently on common latent shocks (Liu, Wang, and Xu 2024). I refer to this as the IFE specification below.

3.1 Identification strategy

The empirical problem is that China’s rise in a country’s trade hierarchy is not randomly assigned. Countries may move closer to China because trade exposure accumulates continuously, because domestic political coalitions or foreign-policy doctrines change, or because governments already inclined toward China deepen commercial ties before the rank reversal occurs. The design therefore asks the identifying question: whether foreign-policy alignment changes around the discrete status threshold after accounting for pre-treatment trajectories and observed sources of economic, geopolitical, and domestic-political orientation.

In the Brazil design, SDiD constructs a weighted counterfactual from pre-treatment information. The covariates are not included simply to improve fit. They proxy observable rival explanations and improve balance on measured trade, geopolitical, and domestic-political factors. Trade shares with China and the United States measure smooth changes in economic exposure; relative power, geographic distance to Washington, and U.S. trade-agreement ties proxy structural exposure to the incumbent power; leader ideology, regime institutions, and macroeconomic stress proxy domestic-

political reorientation and contemporaneous shocks. These covariates do not eliminate unobserved domestic coalitions, doctrines, or shocks. The demand-shock diagnostics further add smooth China-share transformations, export-destination concentration, pre-2009 primary-goods export exposure, and 2008-2009 exposure interactions. The rank-versus-volume timing tests then ask whether earlier trade growth or lower-rank promotions generate the same estimated convergence as the top-rank reversal.

The cross-country panel provides a second check against Brazil-specific timing explanations. Treated countries enter durable China-top goods-export status in different years, so a Brazil-specific 2009 shock cannot mechanically generate the pooled result. Interactive fixed effects allow countries to load differently on common latent shocks, while the appendix reports duration-threshold and risk-set robustness checks.

4 Brazil SDiD evidence

The Brazilian analysis estimates the average post-2009 reduced-form effect of China's entry into the top export-destination position on Brazil's UNGA ideal-point distance to China. It asks whether Brazil moved closer to China than a synthetic counterfactual after the 2009 rank reversal.

Figure 1 shows the timing of the rank threshold. China's export share rose before 2009, but China became the top-ranked export destination only in 2009. The signed margin over the relevant competitor also changes sign at that threshold. The SDiD covariate matrix includes trade shares with China and the United States to account for smooth trade exposure. The rank margin is part of the threshold event itself, so it is used as a timing diagnostic rather than as a separate control.

Figure 2 presents the main SDiD fit. The pre-treatment fit is close enough to make the post-treatment comparison informative, and the post-2009 gap is negative, indicating convergence toward China. The point estimate is -0.26 ideal-point units, with placebo-based SE 0.14 and p-value 0.069. Relative to Brazil's pre-treatment mean distance (0.647), this corresponds to a 40.8 percent reduction. The estimate summarizes the average post-treatment gap. Appendix Figure 6 plots the underlying Brazil and China ideal-point series separately; China is comparatively stable, so the post-2009 reduction in absolute distance is driven mainly by movement in Brazil's position rather than by China

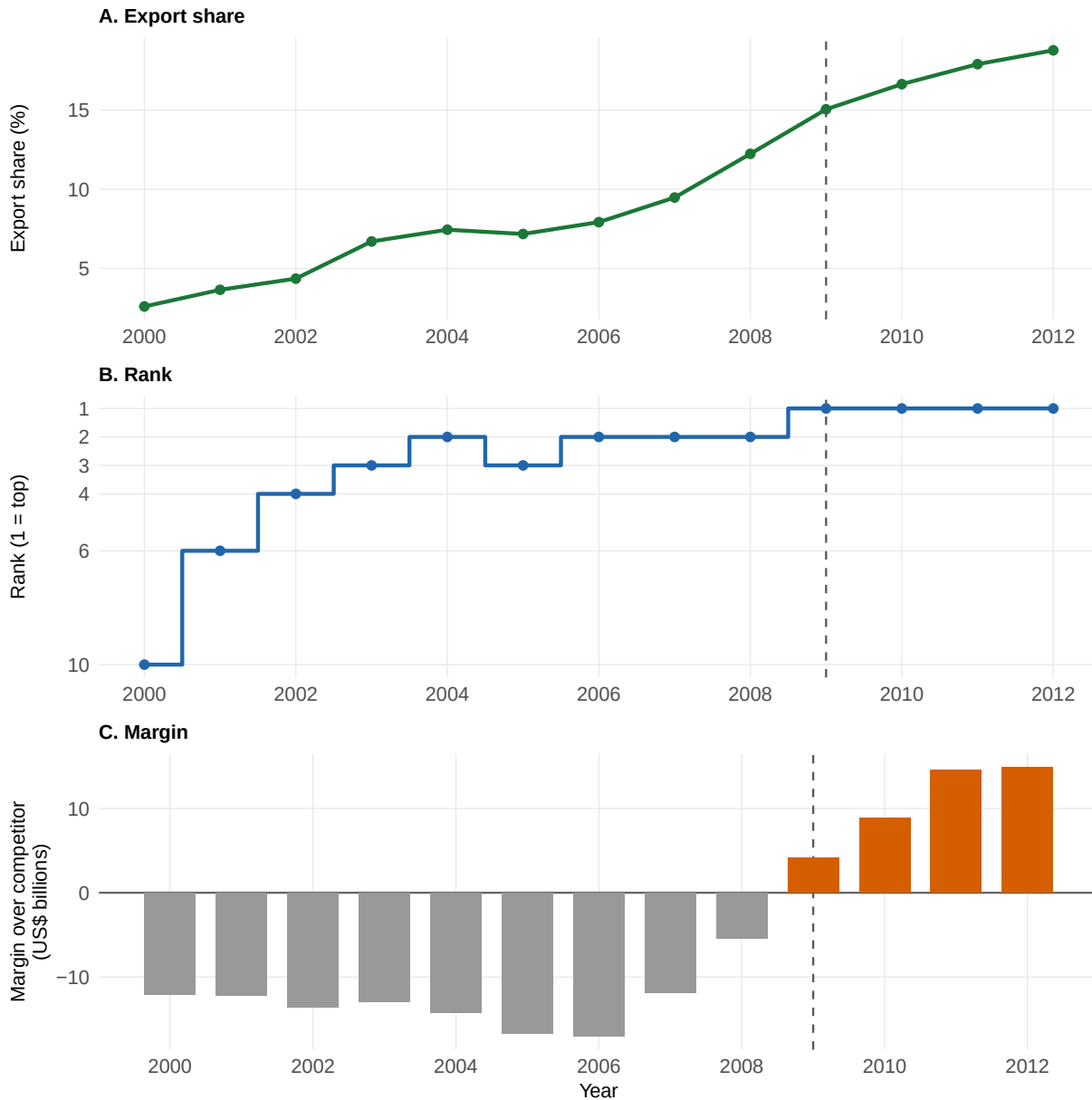


Figure 1: Brazil rank-versus-volume diagnostic for China's export-destination status. Panels show China's export share, ordinal rank, and signed margin over the relevant competitor. The dashed line marks the 2009 rank reversal. Note: Export share in percent; ordinal rank; export-value margin in current USD billions. Window: 2000-2012 annual Brazil series.

moving toward Brazil.

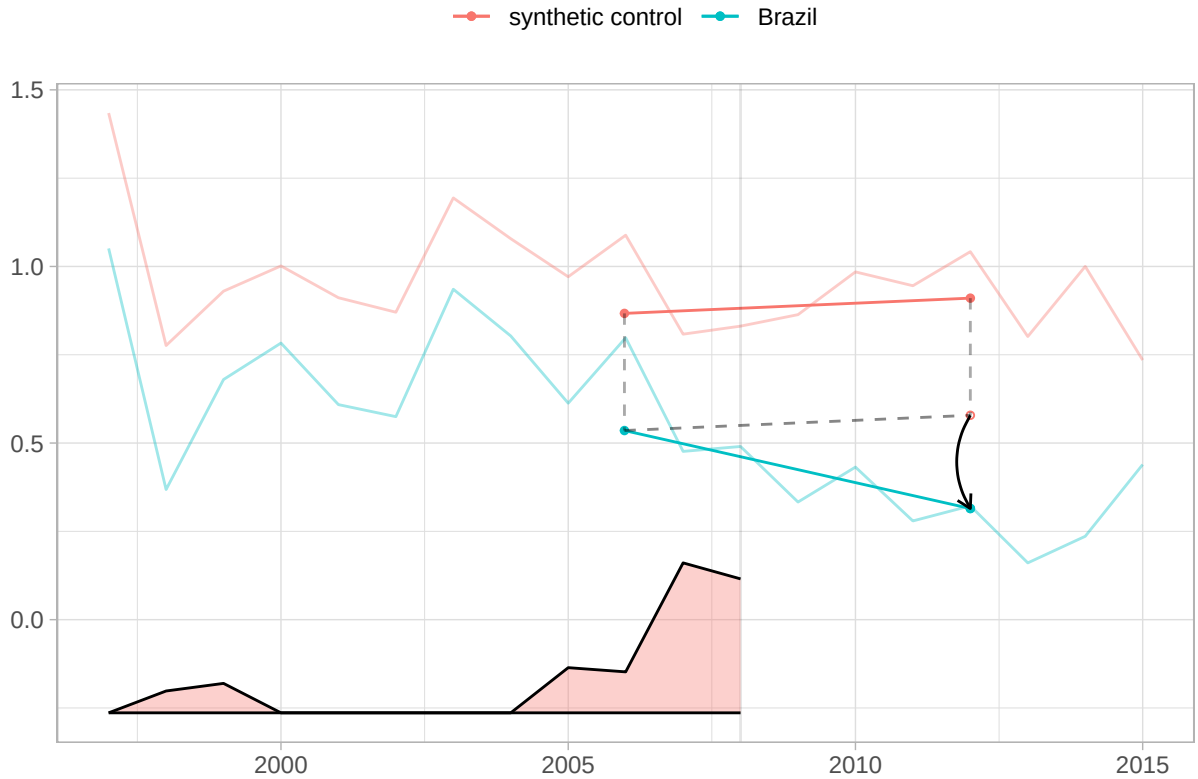


Figure 2: SDiD fit for Brazil and synthetic control with time weights. Lower values indicate convergence toward China; the post-treatment gap is an average post-2009 reduced-form effect. Note: Absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China. SE: placebo-based SE with 1,000 replications; p-values reported in the table. Window: Brazil annual series.

Table 2 reports the preferred Brazil SDiD estimate alongside three specification checks. Each column estimates the average post-2009 gap in Brazil's UNGA ideal-point distance to China and reports a placebo-based standard error. The baseline without institutional covariates, the specification without time-varying covariates, and the Latin America donor pool preserve the negative sign. Column (3) addresses post-treatment-adjustment concerns directly by holding only pre-treatment or time-invariant covariates fixed across panel years; the estimate remains nearly identical to the main specification. Column (1) remains the main specification because it keeps the theoretically relevant donor pool while adjusting for trade exposure, macroeconomic stress, geographic distance to Washington, and institutional covariates.

Table 2: Brazil SDiD estimates across main and robustness specifications.

	(1) Main	(2) No institutional covariates	(3) No time-varying covariates	(4) Latin America donors
ATT	-0.26 (0.14)	-0.26 (0.14)	-0.27 (0.13)	-0.41 (0.21)
<i>Covariates:</i>				
Trade share China	✓	✓	✓	✓
Trade share US	✓	✓	✓	✓
Power index (GPI)	✓	✓		✓
Power gap to US	✓	✓		✓
Per-capita income	✓	✓	✓	✓
Exchange rate	✓	✓		✓
Geographic distance to US	✓	✓	✓	✓
HoG left ideology	✓	✓		✓
Current account (% GDP)	✓	✓		✓
Gov. deficit (% GDP)	✓	✓		✓
Parliamentary system	✓		✓	✓
Military executive	✓			✓
US trade agreement	✓		✓	✓
Country-years	1,824	1,824	1,824	380
Donor countries	95	95	95	19
Donor pool	Global	Global	Global	Latin America
Time window	1997-2015	1997-2015	1997-2015	1997-2015

Note:

The outcome is absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; ATT is the average post-treatment Brazil-minus-synthetic gap, so negative values mean convergence. Placebo-based SEs with 1,000 replications are in parentheses. Checkmarks show included covariate groups. Donor counts exclude Brazil. Column (3) uses pre-treatment or time-invariant covariates held fixed across panel years.

The rank interpretation requires more than showing that trade with China was increasing. Brazil's exports to China grew before 2009, including years in which China rose in the export hierarchy but did not become number one. The timing tests in Table 3 therefore ask whether rapid trade growth and lower-rank promotions generate the same estimated UNGA convergence as the top-rank reversal. They do not. The 2003, 2004, and 2005 rows are timing and lower-threshold falsifications for the continuous-growth alternative: 2004 is especially useful because China first reaches rank #2 but is still not Brazil's largest export destination. The 2012 row probes whether the result is driven by a later break after China had already become the top destination.

The same timing logic addresses the main Brazilian political confounder. President Lula da Silva took office in 2003 and pursued a more explicit South-South foreign-policy agenda, a shift emphasized in work on Brazilian autonomy, presidential foreign policy, and international engagement (Neto 2011; Mourón and Urdinez 2014; Neto and Malamud 2015; P. Rodrigues, Urdinez, and De Oliveira 2019; Luis L. Schenoni et al. 2022). If that ideological shift were sufficient to explain Brazil-China UNGA convergence, the pseudo-treatment years in 2003 or 2005 should already show comparable movement. They do not. The cross-country panel also estimates the rank-threshold pattern across countries with different political systems and leadership profiles, which reduces the concern that the Brazil estimate is only a Lula-period artifact.

A remaining concern is that 2009 bundled the Brazilian rank reversal with other contemporaneous shocks, including the global financial crisis, the BRICS/G20 moment, and the commodity cycle. Table 4 addresses this critique inside the same Brazil SDiD framework. The main estimate is -0.264; after adding pre-2009 primary-goods export exposure and 2008-2009 exposure interactions it is -0.306. The point estimate also remains negative in the full stress test (-0.281), but that specification combines several highly collinear exposure diagnostics and produces unstable placebo inference. I therefore read the evidence conservatively: the categorical China #1 onset is not erased by destination concentration or by predetermined commodity/GFC exposure controls, while the over-saturated stress test is useful mainly as a warning about limited support for simultaneously partialling out every continuous rank-related measure. This does not prove that the rank cue is experimentally isolated from every contemporaneous political shock. It does show that the result is not an artifact of omitting smooth China-demand exposure from the SDiD design.

The cross-country panel below is a broader scope check, not the main answer to the Brazil-specific demand-shock critique. Brazil is included in the goods-only cross-country sample, but the panel aligns countries by their own China-top goods-export entry years. A Brazil-specific 2009 confounder cannot mechanically generate an average event-time effect across countries treated in different calendar years. For such an explanation to account for both the Brazil estimate and the cross-country result, the omitted force would need to coincide with durable China-top entry across countries, affect UNGA distance to China in the same direction, and remain outside the latent factors captured by the interactive fixed-effects specification. In sensitivity-analysis terms, it would

need enough residual association with both treatment timing and the outcome to overturn estimates that are stable across the Brazil timing tests, donor-pool checks, and the cross-country duration and risk-set checks (Cinelli and Hazlett 2020; Oster 2019).

Table 3: Brazil SDiD estimate and rank-versus-volume timing tests.

Timing year	Test role	China rank	Rank-1 reversal	Export share (%)	Margin (USD bn)	ATT	Placebo SE	p-value
2003	Growth / lower-rank promotion	3	No	6.7	-12.9	-0.117	0.178	0.511
2004	China #2 threshold	2	No	7.4	-14.2	-0.131	0.173	0.450
2005	Rapid growth without rank 1	3	No	7.2	-16.7	-0.119	0.146	0.417
2009	Actual rank-1 reversal	1	Yes	15.1	4.1	-0.264	0.145	0.069
2012	Later-break falsification	1	No	18.8	14.9	0.037	0.147	0.803

Note:

Outcome is absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; ATT is the estimated post-onset Brazil-minus-synthetic gap, so negative values mean convergence; export margins are current USD billions. SE: normal approximation using placebo-based SE with 1,000 replications. Window: 2003-2005 timing tests truncate the sample before 2009; 2012 is a later-break falsification. The 2003, 2004, and 2005 rows are timing and lower-threshold falsifications for rapid export growth without rank-1 status.

Table 4: Brazil SDiD diagnostics for the China-demand-shock critique.

Specification	Diagnostic added	ATT	Placebo SE	95% CI	p-value
Main SDiD	Original covariates	-0.264	0.145	[-0.548, 0.020]	0.069
Smooth China share	China-share transformations	-0.247	3.371	[-6.854, 6.360]	0.942
Destination concentration	Concentration	-0.255	0.140	[-0.530, 0.020]	0.070
Commodity/GFC exposure	Predetermined commodity exposure	-0.306	0.148	[-0.595, -0.016]	0.038
Full stress test	All diagnostics including rank margin	-0.281	unstable	not informative	unstable

Note:

Outcome is absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; ATT is the average post-treatment Brazil-minus-synthetic gap, so negative values mean convergence. SE: synthdid placebo SE with 1,000 replications. Window: 1997-2015 annual SDiD panel. All rows keep the binary 2009 China number-one treatment onset. Commodity/GFC exposure uses pre-2009 primary-goods export composition from ITPD-E Agriculture plus Mining and Energy over goods exports, interacted with the 2008-2009 shock window. The full stress test includes the rank margin, which is mechanically related to the threshold, and several continuous exposure transformations; its placebo SE is numerically unstable, so that row is a conservative support diagnostic rather than a preferred inferential specification.

4.1 Issue-Area Evidence: Where Did Convergence Occur?

The aggregate ideal-point estimate raises a substantive question: in what kinds of votes did Brazil move closer to China? Resolution-level diagnostics suggest that the post-2009 convergence was

selective rather than uniform. In several issue areas Brazil and China already voted together at high rates before treatment, leaving little room for additional convergence. The more informative domain is human rights, where pre-treatment agreement was lower and where movement toward China carried greater reputational costs for Brazil, given the domestic and international implications of Brazil's human-rights foreign policy (Milani 2015). In that domain, Brazil-China identical voting increased by 7.5 percentage points after 2009. This pattern is consistent with the proposed mechanism: the trade-rank cue made China's relationship politically usable, allowing policymakers to justify selective convergence in a visible multilateral arena where Brazil had previously maintained more distance.

This descriptive increase does not by itself establish China-specific alignment, because annual issue-area shares can reflect agenda composition and do not compare Brazil with donor countries. I therefore add a more restrictive vote-level diagnostic. In country-resolution regressions with country and resolution fixed effects, restricted to human-rights votes where China and the United States cast different votes, Brazil moves closer to China after 2009 relative to the donor pool. The Brazil-by-post-2009 coefficient is -0.361 for distance to China minus distance to the United States (model-based SE = 0.021), and -0.418 when the sample is restricted to strong yes/no China-US disagreements (model-based SE = 0.023). The corresponding non-human-rights estimate is smaller (-0.132, model-based SE = 0.012), and a DDD specification estimates an additional human-rights increment of -0.275 (model-based SE = 0.055). Because Brazil is the single treated country in this diagnostic, I use country placebos as the main inferential benchmark: Brazil ranks 6 out of 95 units in the China-specific direction (directional $p = 0.063$; strict donor-only $p = 0.053$). These diagnostics support a narrower interpretation: the post-2009 movement is strongest in human-rights votes where China and the United States diverged, rather than uniformly across the UNGA agenda.

Table 5: Brazil-China identical UNGA votes by issue area, before and after 2009.

Issue area	Pre-2009 identical vote share	Post-2009 identical vote share	Change	Interpretation
Human rights	69.6	77.1	7.5	Politically costly convergence; mechanism-informative
Arms/disarmament/nuclear	83.0	84.3	1.2	Diagnostic evidence
Economic development	92.9	90.0	-2.9	Diagnostic evidence
Decolonization	94.1	98.1	4.0	Diagnostic evidence
Palestine/Middle East	100.0	100.0	0.0	High baseline agreement; limited room to move
Other / uncoded	73.4	83.1	9.7	Heterogeneous residual category

Note:

Percentage of roll-call resolutions with identical Brazil-China votes. Window: 2005-2008 versus 2009-2012; multi-coded resolutions enter each issue family. Rows are label-specific diagnostics, not a mutually exclusive decomposition of the aggregate convergence pattern.

Figure 3 disaggregates the same diagnostic by year and substantive issue family. Because several areas already had high Brazil-China vote similarity before 2009, the figure describes where additional convergence was possible.

This issue-area evidence is a diagnostic of substantive content, not a standalone causal test. The SDiD estimate identifies the average post-2009 gap in Brazil's ideal-point distance to China; the vote-level evidence clarifies where that movement is most visible. The strongest support comes from human-rights resolutions in which China and the United States diverged, where Brazil moves closer to China relative to comparable donor countries after 2009. A DDD comparison shows that the human-rights shift is larger than the analogous non-human-rights shift. Country placebos counsel against language implying that Brazil is unique. The Brazil evidence therefore supports a cautious claim of selective UNGA adjustment toward China in politically visible domains, rather than a claim that the issue-area table alone proves selective convergence.

5 Brazilian media salience

To assess whether the rank reversal became publicly salient, I examine coverage of China in *Folha de S.Paulo*, Brazil's widest-circulation newspaper (*Folha de S.Paulo* 2016), from 2000 to 2014. Salience matters because the rank-threshold argument requires the top-rank cue to become politically usable. A change in export hierarchy can shape elite and public attention when it appears in a prominent national newspaper as a simple signal of China's commercial importance, consistent with



Figure 3: Brazil-China identical UNGA votes by issue area, 2005-2012. Points report annual shares; the vertical line marks 2009. The clearest pattern expected by the mechanism is selective convergence in human rights. Note: Percentage of roll-call resolutions with identical Brazil-China votes. Window: 2005-2012 annual series; multi-coded resolutions enter each issue family.

work on media, agenda setting, and foreign policy (Soroka 2003; Baum and Potter 2008; Walgrave and Van Aelst 2006).

Headlines are the appropriate unit for this diagnostic because the mechanism is public attention and categorical labeling. This follows corpus-assisted media studies that use headlines because they are tractable in large archives and operate as attention-directing cues (Zhang and Yu 2024). The relevant question is whether *Folha* increasingly foregrounded China as a trade relationship after the rank reversal. Headlines are the most visible textual cue in the archive, they are the part of coverage most likely to be scanned by broad audiences, and they are where newspapers condense complex developments into short public labels such as “largest trade partner” or “record exports.” Full article texts would be useful for a different exercise – for example, measuring tone or detailed argumentation – but the salience claim here is about which China-related themes were made visible at the headline level.

I therefore classify China-related headlines into substantive categories and then collapse them into four analytically relevant groups: China-Brazil trade, China’s domestic economy, diplomacy and bilateral relations, and non-economic coverage. The classification uses a fixed label set with examples, and the appendix reports the exact prompt and validation procedure. Figure 4 shows that the post-2009 increase is concentrated in China-Brazil trade coverage rather than in all China-related topics equally. This pattern is consistent with a rank-salience interpretation: coverage concentrates on China’s new commercial status in Brazil.

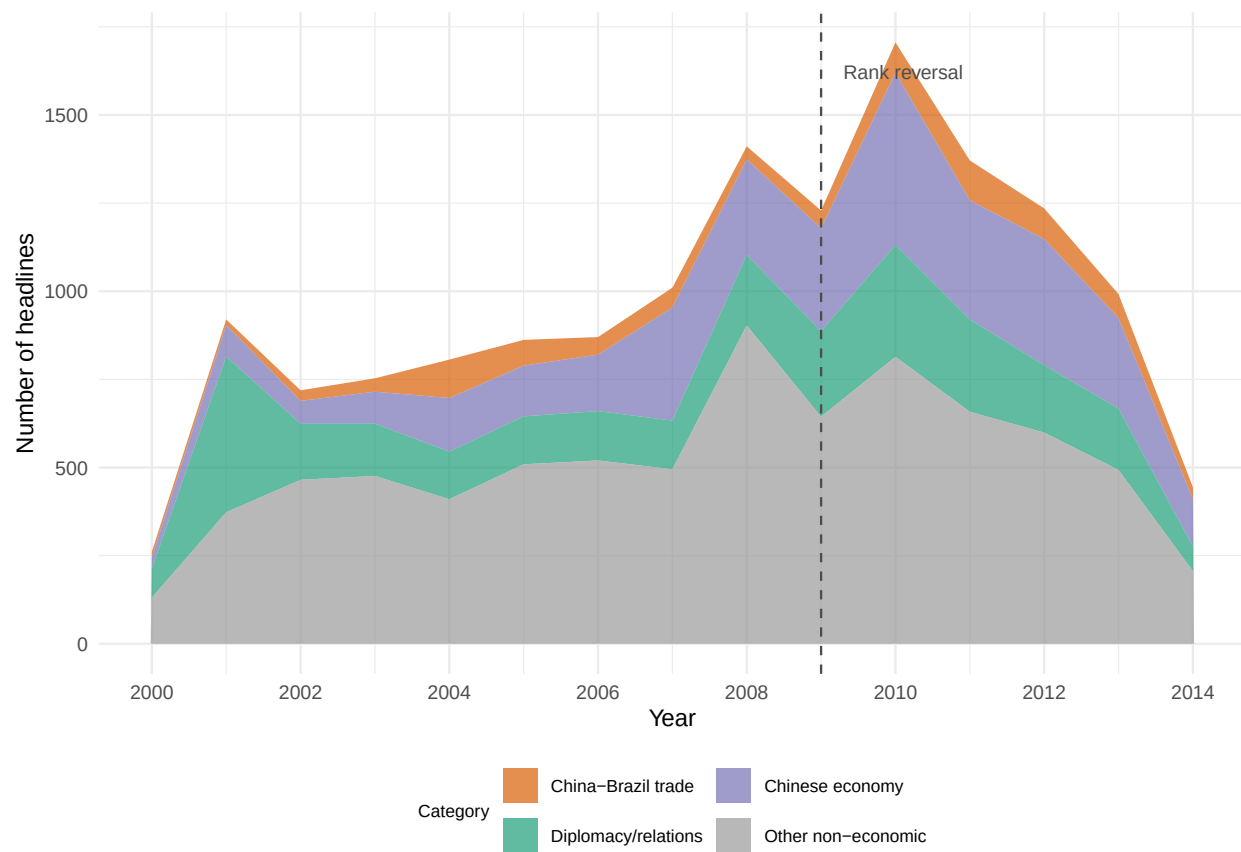


Figure 4: Brazilian media salience: disaggregated China headlines in Folha de S.Paulo by category. The sustained post-2009 increase is concentrated in trade-related coverage. Note: Headlines per category per year. Window: 2000-2014 annual series.

The media evidence identifies the attention step in the mechanism. The status cue became publicly available during the 2009 treatment year, before the full-year trade table was finalized. In early May, contemporary coverage of January–April trade statistics reported a historic shift in Brazil’s trade hierarchy: China had become Brazil’s largest trading partner and had purchased US\$5.627 billion in Brazilian exports, compared with US\$4.925 billion purchased by the United States (Agência Brasil 2009). This real-time visibility matters for the mechanism. The empirical design codes treatment annually because the outcome and comparative trade data are annual, but officials, journalists, and firms encountered the rank cue through contemporaneous monthly and year-to-date statistics. Lula’s May 2009 Beijing visit therefore provides evidence of official uptake during the treatment year: the new rank was already available as a public category around which diplomatic priorities could be narrated. Brazilian officials then repeatedly invoked China’s new position in Brazil’s trade hierarchy when explaining diplomatic prioritization, bilateral upgrading, and institutional follow-up.

In a written interview on the eve of his May 2009 visit to Beijing, President Lula described China as Brazil’s leading trading partner and framed the trip as an effort to consolidate cooperation across commerce, technology, and global economic governance (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2009, 323). In Beijing three days later, Lula repeated the rank claim in speeches organized around the Brazil-China Strategic Partnership, trade diversification, investment, presidential diplomacy, and the preparation of the 2010–2014 Joint Action Plan (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2009, 115, 121–22). The cue then persisted in Itamaraty language. When announcing Hu Jintao’s 2010 state visit and the signature of the Joint Action Plan, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs again invoked China’s 2009 rise to the top of Brazil’s trade hierarchy (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2010, 356). Dilma Rousseff and Hu Jintao’s 2011 joint communiqué likewise noted that China had become Brazil’s principal trading partner in 2009 and embedded that status in an agenda of intensified dialogue over trade, investment, diversification, and implementation of the Joint Action Plan (Ministério das Relações Exteriores and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2011a, 160–61). Later that year, Foreign Minister Antonio Patriota made the institutional link explicit: in discussing China, he announced a dedicated Itamaraty task force to monitor economic-commercial relations with Brazil’s principal trading partner and to propose ways to move the relationship beyond complementarity, toward diversification and higher value-added trade (Ministério das Relações Exteriores

and Fundação Alexandre de Gusmão 2011b, 47).

These statements show that the 2009 status cue was absorbed into official language and used to justify diplomatic prioritization and institutional attention. This is precisely the public justificatory mechanism implied by the theory: once China was officially recognized as central in Brazil's economic hierarchy, selective diplomatic accommodation could be presented as pragmatic recognition of national economic interests rather than as ideological concession or opportunistic bandwagoning.

6 Cross-Country Evidence Beyond Brazil

The cross-country analysis serves two purposes. First, it tests whether durable top-rank goods-export status has consequences beyond the Brazilian case. Second, it is an additional robustness check against explanations tied to Brazil's 2009 calendar year, such as the global financial crisis, the BRICS/G20 moment, or the commodity cycle. If durable top-rank trade status matters, countries where China enters and holds the largest goods export-destination position should move closer to China in UNGA ideal-point space when aligned by their own treatment entry. I therefore estimate the same treatment logic in a goods-only status-current panel: treated country-years are those where China is rank 1 among goods export destinations and the China-top period lasts at least five observed years. Never-China-top countries remain controls. Short China-top episodes and post-exit off-status years for treated countries are removed from the main risk set. This analysis tests whether the rank-threshold pattern travels beyond the theory-generating case while matching the durable treatment observed in Brazil.

The preferred cross-country specification is the no-covariate IFE model on the goods-only restricted risk set. The estimate is -0.101 ideal-point units (bootstrap SE = 0.039, 95 percent CI [-0.177, -0.024], $p = 0.010$). It corresponds to about 14.0 percent of the pre-treatment mean distance to China, or 0.124 standard deviations of the outcome. The estimate is in the theoretically expected negative direction and statistically distinguishable from zero at the 5 percent level. The clean single-entry robustness estimate is -0.122 ($p = 0.003$). The switching-allowed estimate is smaller, -0.037 ($p = 0.214$), which is consistent with attenuation when short China-top periods and post-exit off-status years are allowed into the comparison structure. The cross-country evidence is smaller than the Brazil SDiD effect, consistent with Brazil being a most-likely case in which China displaced the

United States and the rank reversal was publicly salient. The direction is the same: durable China-top goods-export status is associated with reduced UNGA distance to China beyond the Brazilian case. Appendix Tables 8 and 10 report duration-threshold robustness and sample-coding audits.

Table 6: Cross-country IFE estimates for durable China top goods export-destination status.

Model	Estimator	ATT	SE	95% CI	p-value	Units (T/C)	Treated periods	Panel window	r*
Status-current, restricted risk set	IFE	-0.101	0.039	[-0.177, -0.024]	0.010	35/126	440	1990–2022	2
Clean single-entry robustness	IFE	-0.122	0.041	[-0.202, -0.042]	0.003	25/126	329	1990–2022	2
Status-current, switching allowed	IFE	-0.037	0.030	[-0.096, 0.022]	0.214	24/89	297	1990–2022	1

Note:

ATT in absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; lower values indicate convergence toward China. SE: bootstrap with 10,000 replications. Window: 1990–2022 goods-only cross-country panel. Goods-only ranks are computed from ITPD-E Agriculture, Mining and Energy, and Manufacturing sectors; Services are excluded before ranks are constructed. Units (T/C) = treated/control units. For IFE rows, r* is the number of latent factors selected by cross-validation over $r = 0:3$. The restricted risk-set row is the main cross-country estimate. The clean single-entry row excludes treated countries with multiple China-top periods. The switching-allowed row is a lower-bound robustness check that keeps a balanced status-current panel.

Figure 5 shows the entry-aligned dynamic pattern for the main goods-only restricted-risk-set IFE specification. The pre-entry estimates are diagnostics for model fit, and the post-entry path indicates whether the panel pattern is consistent with the Brazil result.

The two designs test nested implications of the argument. Brazil is the high-salience case: China displaced the United States, the hegemonic benchmark, and the attention mechanism can be observed directly in media and official discourse. The cross-country panel tests a broader scope implication: whether durable China-top goods export-destination status is followed by movement toward China when local salience is less directly observable. The panel estimate should therefore be interpreted as scope evidence rather than as a substitute for the Brazilian mechanism test.

The cross-country treatment is durable status-current China-top goods export-destination status, the exposure rule implied by the theory’s durability condition. The corresponding estimand is the ATT on absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China for country-years in qualifying China-top periods.

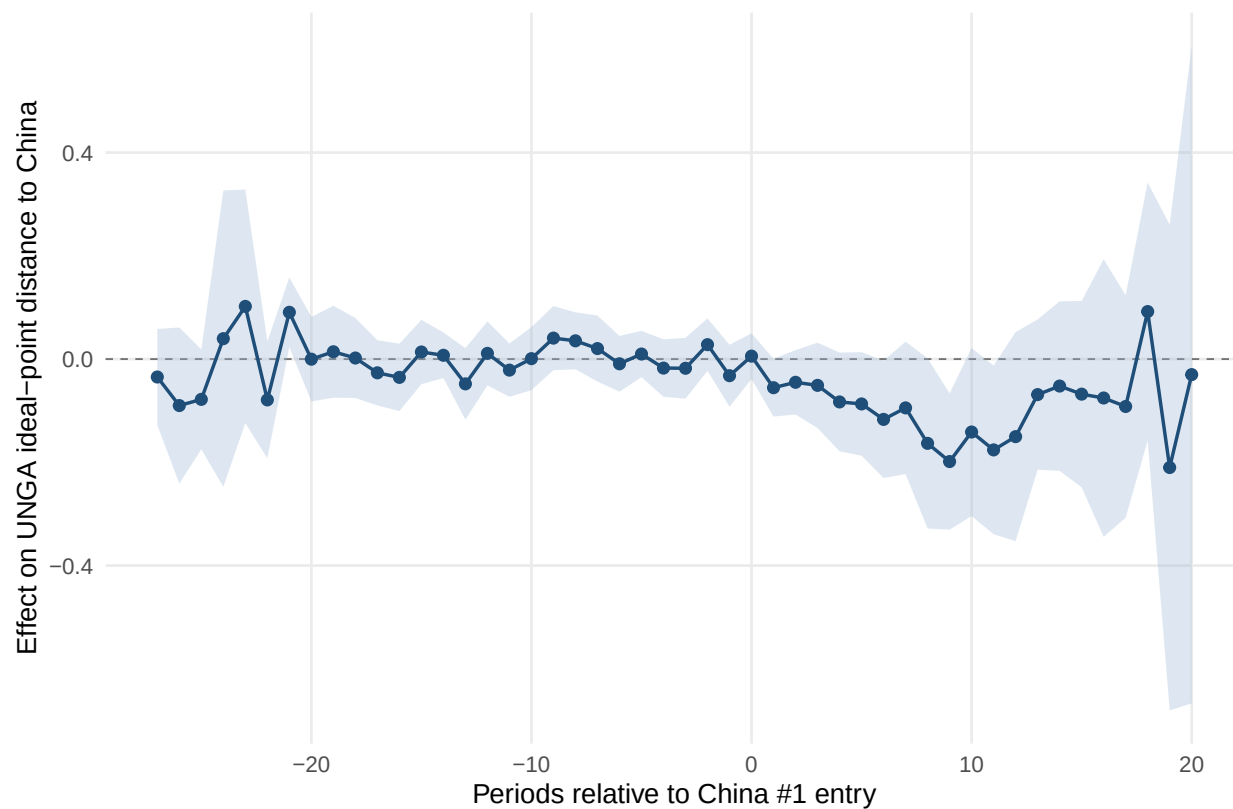


Figure 5: Entry-aligned dynamic effects from the main goods-only cross-country IFE model. Negative estimates indicate reduced UNGA distance to China after entry into durable China-top goods export-destination status. Note: Effect on absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China. SE: bootstrap confidence intervals. Window: 1990–2022 goods-only panel.

7 Conclusion

The evidence supports a rank-threshold account of UNGA voting convergence toward China. In Brazil, China's 2009 move into the top export-destination position coincided with a publicly visible status cue, and SDiD estimates show that Brazil moved closer to China relative to a synthetic counterfactual. The issue-area and vote-level evidence suggest that this convergence was selective rather than mechanical: the strongest additional support comes from human-rights resolutions where China and the United States diverged, and the human-rights shift is larger than the analogous non-human-rights shift. The media evidence shows why the rank cue was politically usable: China's new commercial status became visible in *Folha* headlines and official discourse. Cross-country estimates from the goods-only IFE model then show that the rank-threshold pattern travels beyond Brazil. The mechanism is measured most directly in the Brazilian case, and the panel evidence extends the argument beyond the theory-generating case: durable top-rank goods-export milestones can matter for multilateral alignment.

The paper therefore shifts attention from trade volume alone to the political meaning of trade hierarchies. Continuous exposure matters, but actors also respond to categorical milestones: becoming first, displacing a hegemonic benchmark, and making an economic relationship publicly legible. These thresholds can create opportunities for selective diplomatic adjustment even when the underlying commercial relationship has been growing for years.

Future research can extend the design in three directions. First, cross-country media data would allow the salience step to be tested beyond Brazil. Second, qualitative work on policymakers and business actors could identify how the rank cue entered diplomatic deliberation. Third, similar rank-threshold designs could be applied to investment, aid, lending, or other economic ties where categorical milestones may become politically usable.

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8 Appendix

We present more details about the performance and checks on the fitted model and how we used ChatGPT to perform the NLP analysis.

8.1 Brazil and China Ideal-Point Series

Figure 6 plots the separate UNGA ideal-point series for Brazil and China. This diagnostic clarifies the interpretation of the absolute-distance outcome used in the main SDiD design: China remains comparatively stable, while Brazil accounts for most of the movement in the Brazil-China distance.

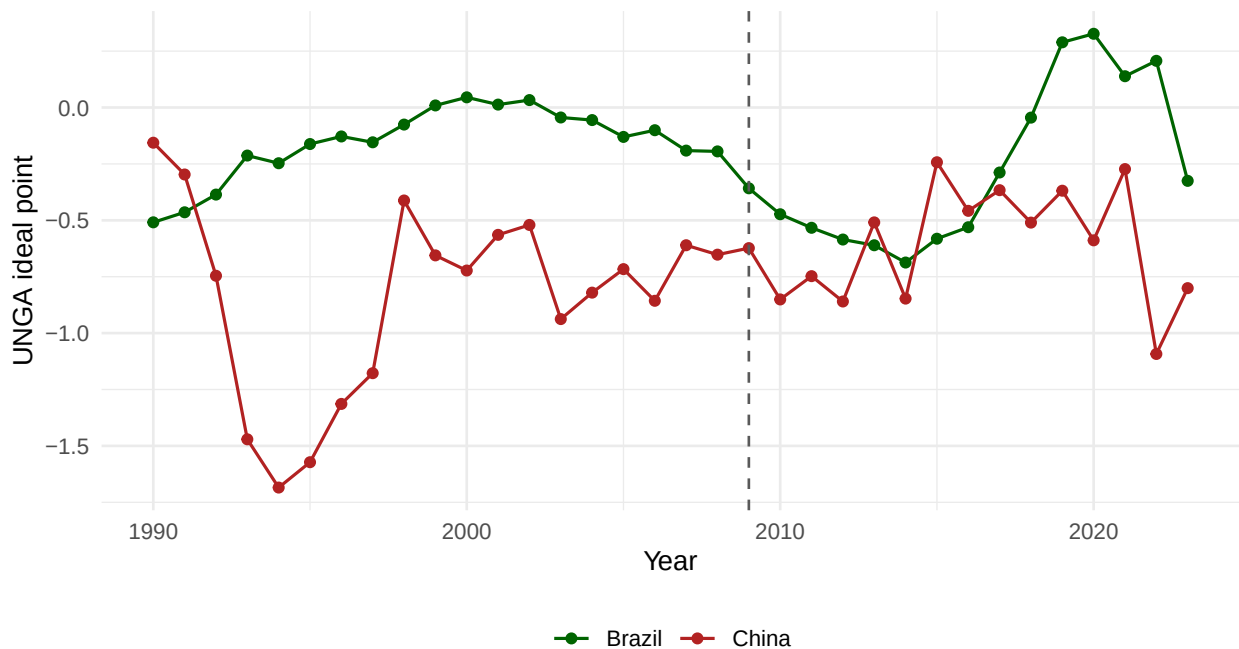


Figure 6: Brazil and China UNGA ideal-point series. The dashed line marks 2009. The figure separates the two series behind the absolute-distance outcome used in the main SDiD analysis. Note: UNGA ideal-point score (Bailey et al. scale). Window: 1990-2022 annual series.

8.2 Resolution-Level UNGA Vote Diagnostics

To make the Brazil-China movement in UNGA ideal points more concrete, Table 7 reports the annual share of resolutions in which Brazil and China cast identical votes from 2005 to 2012. The diagnostic uses roll-call votes from unvotes 0.3.0, based on Erik Voeten's UNGA voting data, and excludes missing or absent votes by either Brazil or China.

Table 7: Brazil-China identical UNGA votes by year, 2005-2012.

Year	Resolutions	Identical votes	Identical votes (%)	Mean similarity score
2005	97	80	82.5	0.892
2006	108	88	81.5	0.884
2007	93	78	83.9	0.903
2008	96	73	76.0	0.859
2009	83	72	86.7	0.934
2010	85	74	87.1	0.906
2011	96	83	86.5	0.927
2012	90	71	78.9	0.872

Note:

Roll-call resolutions with valid Brazil and China votes; similarity score ranges from 0 to 1. Window: 2005-2012 annual series.

8.3 SDiD

8.3.1 Comparison of DiD, SCM, and SDiD estimating equations

To gain intuition for the SDiD estimator, it is useful to compare it with standard DiD and SCM. A DiD model estimates:

$$(\hat{\tau}_{ATT}^{DiD}, \hat{\mu}, \hat{\alpha}, \hat{\beta}) = \arg \min_{\tau_{ATT}, \mu, \alpha, \beta} \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{t=1}^T (Y_{it} - \mu - \alpha_i - \beta_t - D_{it}\tau_{ATT})^2$$

While SDiD assigns weights to the control group that are more similar to those of the treated unit and in time periods comparable to the pre-treatment period, classic DiD does not use any weights at all.

The SCM model can be written as follows:

$$(\hat{\tau}_{ATT}^{SCM}, \hat{\mu}, \hat{\beta}) = \arg \min_{\tau_{ATT}, \mu, \beta} \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{t=1}^T \hat{w}_i^{SCM} (Y_{it} - \mu - \beta_t - D_{it}\tau_{ATT})^2$$

Here $\hat{w}_i^{SCM}$ is the donor-unit weight assigned to unit i . SCM uses these donor weights to match

the treated unit's pre-treatment outcome path, and effects are then read from post-treatment treated-minus-synthetic gaps. SCM can approximate stable unit differences through donor weights when the treated unit lies in the donor convex hull, but it does not add unit fixed effects or time weights. SDiD combines unit weights (like SCM) with unit fixed effects and time weights (like DiD), addressing the limitations of both. The basic SDiD estimating equation is:

$$(\hat{\tau}_{ATT}^{SDiD}, \hat{\mu}, \hat{\alpha}, \hat{\beta}) = \arg \min_{\tau_{ATT}, \mu, \beta, \alpha} \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{t=1}^T \hat{w}_i^{SDiD} \hat{\lambda}_t^{SDiD} (Y_{it} - \mu - \alpha_i - \beta_t - D_{it} \tau_{ATT})^2$$

Note that SDiD retains unit fixed effects α_i (like DiD) while also assigning unit weights $\hat{w}_i^{SDiD}$ (like SCM) and time weights $\hat{\lambda}_t^{SDiD}$ (unique to SDiD).

8.3.2 SDiD weights and donor pool

Below we present the ten largest donor weights used in the main model.

We also fit a model for a donor pool of Latin American states (excluding Caribbean countries), which is substantively attractive because the donor countries are regionally closer to Brazil. This regional donor pool is a sensitivity check rather than the preferred specification: the main design seeks a pre-treatment synthetic counterfactual with adequate donor support and fit, while the Latin American pool is much smaller.

The Latin America donor-pool estimate has the same sign as the main estimate, but it is less precise and substantially larger in magnitude: -0.41 with a standard error of 0.21, compared with -0.26 in the main donor pool. I therefore treat it as evidence that the negative sign is not unique to the global donor pool, not as evidence that the two counterfactuals produce nearly identical magnitudes. The countries with the largest Latin American weights are Argentina, Guatemala, Paraguay, and Uruguay – all but Guatemala are founding members of Mercosur.

8.4 Cross-Country Robustness: Duration Thresholds

The main cross-country estimate uses a five-year durability threshold because the theory concerns status that persists long enough to become politically usable. Table 8 reports the same goods-only IFE design under three- and seven-year thresholds, along with the clean single-entry robustness

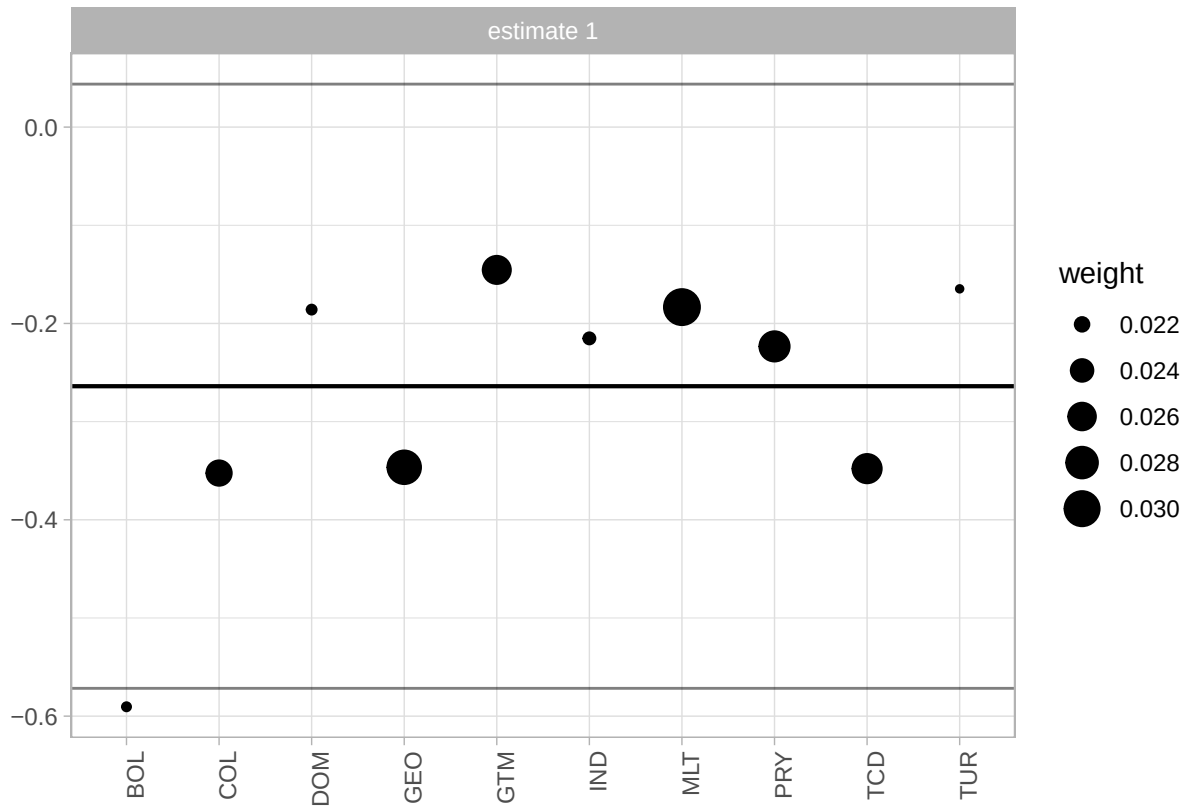


Figure 7: Ten largest donor weights contributing to the synthetic control in the Brazilian SDiD model. Note: Synthetic-control unit weights, normalized over the full donor pool rather than only over the displayed donors. Window: pre-treatment period ending in 2008.

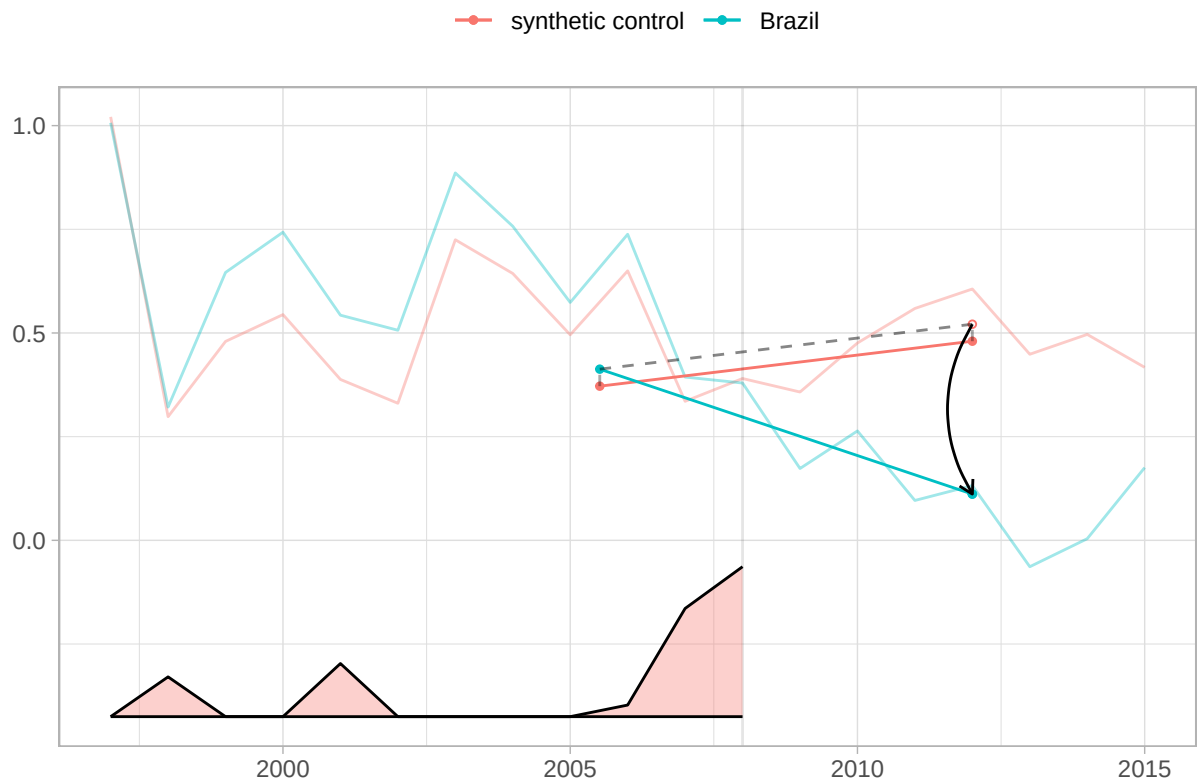


Figure 8: SDiD fit with a Latin American donor pool. Note: Absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China. SE: placebo-based, reported in text. Window: years shown in the plot.

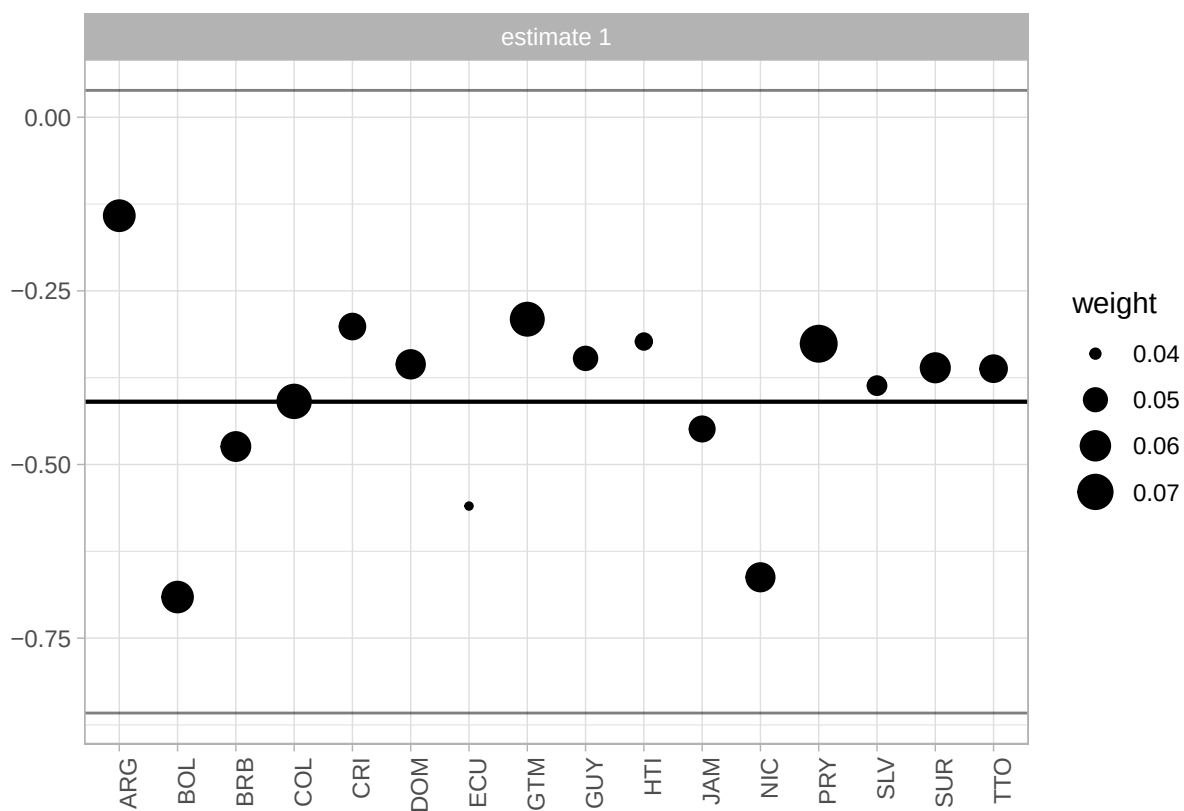


Figure 9: Synthetic-control donor weights for the Latin American SDiD specification. Note: Synthetic-control unit weights, summing to 1. Window: pre-treatment period ending in 2008.

sample. The estimates remain negative across the restricted-risk-set rows, though precision varies with treated-unit support.

Table 8: Duration-threshold robustness for goods-only China top export-destination status.

Minimum duration	Specification	ATT	SE	95% CI	p-value	Units (T/C)	Treated periods	r*
3	Status-current, restricted risk set	-0.113	0.041	[-0.193, -0.034]	0.005	39/126	477	2
3	Clean single-entry robustness	-0.121	0.041	[-0.202, -0.040]	0.003	26/126	332	2
5	Status-current, restricted risk set	-0.101	0.039	[-0.177, -0.024]	0.010	35/126	440	2
5	Clean single-entry robustness	-0.122	0.041	[-0.202, -0.042]	0.003	25/126	329	2
7	Status-current, restricted risk set	-0.094	0.040	[-0.173, -0.016]	0.019	31/126	411	2
7	Clean single-entry robustness	-0.122	0.042	[-0.205, -0.039]	0.004	23/126	318	2

Note:

ATT in absolute UNGA ideal-point distance to China; lower values indicate convergence toward China. SE: bootstrap with 10,000 replications. Window: goods-only ITPD-E rank metric. The restricted-risk-set rows retain clean pre-entry non-China-top years and qualifying treated years. The clean single-entry rows additionally keep only treated countries with one observed qualifying China-top period.

8.5 Cross-Country Sample Audit: Goods-Only Treatment Coding

The revised rank metric excludes services before partner ranks are computed. Table 9 documents the ITPD-E broad-sector filter. Table 10 then summarizes how the five-year goods-only rule classifies countries in the UNGA/trade panel.

Table 9: ITPD-E sector filter used to construct the goods-only China top export-destination metric.

Broad sector	Raw rows	Positive-trade rows	Included in rank metric
Agriculture	7331458	2484549	Yes
Manufacturing	71208330	28203707	Yes
Mining and Energy	1205032	416413	Yes
Services	1002558	519520	No

Table 10: Country-level sample audit for the five-year goods-only China top export-destination rule.

Role	Countries
Excluded: no clean observed prior non-China-top year	1
Excluded: pre-2000 China-top entry	2
Excluded: short China-top periods	26
Never-China-top controls	128
Qualifying treated countries	35

Note:

The audit uses the goods-only rank metric and classifies countries before the estimator-specific screen for minimum untreated support. Country counts are therefore a coding audit, not a replacement for the treated/control counts in the estimation table.

8.6 ChatGPT Classification

Below is the coded instruction to the ChatGPT API to classify the subjects of the headlines.

```
system_block <- paste(
  'You are a Brazilian expert in International Relations and the political',
  'economy of China-Brazil relations. Classify the subject of EACH headline',
  'when I say EACH, I mean all of them, even if repetitive or similar. Do classify **all',
  'using **one** label from this list exactly as written:',
  '"diplomacy", "chinese economy", "china-brasil relations",' ,
  '"disaster and accidents", "chinese politics and policy",' ,
  '"sports, science, culture, other", "human rights",' ,
  '"china-brazil trade", "health".\n\n',
  # 13 static few-shot examples - leave them unchanged!
  'Examples:\n',
  '1. Presidente chinês visita o Brasil e participa de reunião com FHC -> china-brasil r',
  '2. Ministro chinês de Defesa faz visita oficial ao Brasil -> china-brasil relations\n',
  '3. Para governo, novo câmbio chinês só beneficia Brasil no médio prazo -> china-brazi',
  '4. China ultrapassa EUA como maior parceiro comercial do Brasil -> china-brazil trade',
  '5. China vai controlar preços de alimentos e combustíveis -> chinese economy\n',
  '6. Vendas de automóveis na China desaceleram em junho -> chinese economy\n',
  '7. China quer devolução das relíquias Yin, patrimônio da Unesco -> sports, science, c',
  '8. Dinossauro encontrado na China esclarece origem das aves -> sports, science, cultu',
  '9. OMS confirma mais de 4.600 casos de gripe suína; China registra 2º caso -> health\n',
  '10. Marinha chinesa busca "cansar" barcos japoneses em águas disputadas -> diplomacy\n',
  '11. Acidente após casamento deixa 16 mortos na China -> disaster and accidents\n',
  '12. Jornal chinês sai das bancas por foto da praça Tiananmen -> human rights\n',
  '13. China é parceira estratégica contra crise econômica, diz UE -> chinese economy',
  'return as in the examples, a string with the headline and the classification'
)
```

The classified headline file is treated as an archived derived dataset rather than regenerated during

manuscript rendering. This choice reflects the practical behavior of LLM-based coding: early runs sometimes returned incomplete classifications, altered original headlines, or used slightly inconsistent labels, which made exact matching back to the archive difficult. I therefore fixed the prompt, normalized labels, preserved the resulting classified file, and validate the coding below against an independently coded sample. The evidence in the main text is used as a headline-level salience diagnostic.

Below we provide a random sample of the headlines and the classification provided by ChatGPT.

TABLE 1 — Examples of Classified Headlines Random sample of 20 headlines with ChatGPT-assigned topic	
Headline	Date
china-brazil relations	
Disputa com Brasil é 'conflito menor' para China, dizem analistas	2005-10-05
Lula vai se encontrar com presidente da China na segunda	2004-05-23
china-brazil trade	
China lidera as aquisições de empresas brasileiras	2013-03-01
China aceita nova regra brasileira e suspende embargo à soja	2004-06-21
chinese economy	
PIB da China dobra participação no total mundial em 5 anos	2011-03-25
BHP prevê produção recorde de minério de ferro e aposta na China	2012-01-18
chinese politics and policy	
China ameaça Google com "consequências" caso empresa largue autocensura	2010-03-12
China anuncia fechamento de 700 websites	2004-08-01
diplomacy	
China não quer interferência dos EUA na questão do Tibete	2011-09-28
Chega a Taiwan primeiro voo direto da China em quase 60 anos	2008-07-04
disaster and accidents	
Incêndio em prédio residencial deixa 12 mortos na China	2010-07-19
China detona barragens e prédios danificados; veja vídeo	2008-06-06
health	
Uma em três chinesas da zona rural se mata por ano	2002-11-29
China suspende viagens ao Tibete para controlar Sars	2003-05-13
human rights	

Figure 10: Random sample of China-related Folha de Sao Paulo headlines and ChatGPT classifications. Note: headline text and category labels. Window: sample drawn from the 2000-2014 corpus.

8.6.1 Validation of ChatGPT Classification

To assess the reliability of the automated classification, one of the authors independently coded a stratified random sample of 100 headlines (with a minimum of 5 per category). Table 11 reports the agreement rate between the ChatGPT labels and the manual coding.

Table 11: Validation of ChatGPT classification against manual coding (N = 100). Overall accuracy: 88.0 percent.

Category	N	Correct	Accuracy (%)
china-brazil trade	6	6	100.0
disaster and accidents	13	13	100.0
health	6	6	100.0
chinese economy	25	24	96.0
human rights	8	7	87.5
diplomacy	12	10	83.3
sports, science, culture, other	17	14	82.4
china-brazil relations	5	4	80.0
chinese politics and policy	8	4	50.0
Overall	100	88	88.0

Note:

headline-level counts and accuracy (percent) by category. Window: stratified validation sample from the 2000-2014 headline corpus.

The overall accuracy is 88.0 percent. The lowest agreement is in the “chinese politics and policy” category (50.0 percent), where several headlines were manually reclassified as “diplomacy”. The category most central to the mechanism, “china-brazil trade,” achieved 100.0 percent agreement. Related bilateral categories had lower but still usable agreement: 80.0 percent for “china-brazil relations” and 83.3 percent for “diplomacy.”

8.7 Cross-Country: Goods-Only Treated Countries

Table 12 describes the 35 treated countries in the main goods-only restricted-risk-set specification. For each country, the table reports the first qualifying China-top goods-export year and the number

of treated and untreated country-years retained in the estimation panel.

Table 12: Treated countries in the main goods-only restricted-risk-set cross-country specification.

Country	ISO3c	Treatment year	Treated years	Pre/other untreated years	First panel year	Last panel year
Sudan	SDN	2000	6	10	1990	2005
Solomon Islands	SLB	2003	20	13	1990	2022
South Korea	KOR	2003	20	12	1991	2022
Cuba	CUB	2004	18	14	1990	2022
Oman	OMN	2004	19	13	1990	2022
Philippines	PHL	2005	18	15	1990	2022
Yemen	YEM	2005	11	13	1991	2015
Mauritania	MRT	2006	17	15	1990	2022
Angola	AGO	2007	16	17	1990	2022
Chile	CHL	2007	16	17	1990	2022
Iran	IRN	2007	13	17	1990	2019
Kazakhstan	KAZ	2007	16	15	1992	2022
Congo - Kinshasa	COD	2008	14	18	1990	2022
Japan	JPN	2008	15	18	1990	2022
North Korea	PRK	2008	12	13	1991	2019
Thailand	THA	2008	14	18	1990	2021
Australia	AUS	2009	14	19	1990	2022
Brazil	BRA	2009	14	19	1990	2022
Malaysia	MYS	2009	14	19	1990	2022
South Africa	ZAF	2009	14	15	1994	2022
Peru	PER	2010	13	20	1990	2022
Turkmenistan	TKM	2010	13	18	1992	2022
Congo - Brazzaville	COG	2011	12	18	1990	2022
Zimbabwe	ZWE	2011	7	21	1990	2017
Russia	RUS	2012	11	20	1992	2022
Sierra Leone	SLE	2012	11	22	1990	2022
New Zealand	NZL	2013	10	23	1990	2022
Saudi Arabia	SAU	2013	10	23	1990	2022
Uruguay	URY	2013	10	23	1990	2022
Eritrea	ERI	2014	9	21	1993	2022
Myanmar (Burma)	MMR	2014	9	24	1990	2022
Indonesia	IDN	2016	7	25	1990	2022
Equatorial Guinea	GNQ	2017	6	18	1995	2022
Gabon	GAB	2017	6	27	1990	2022
Kuwait	KWT	2018	5	28	1990	2022

Note:

Ranks are computed from goods exports only. The restricted risk set keeps clean pre-entry non-China-top years and qualifying treated years for treated countries. Treatment year is the first retained year of a qualifying China-top goods-export period.